

Home computers

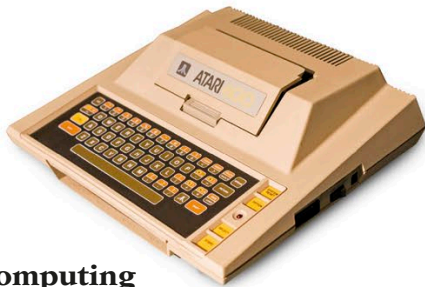
Since the arrival of the earliest personal computers, which were boxy and heavy, the trend has been towards ever smaller devices with greater processing power. The computing power of our smartphones is far greater than that of early computers that were the size of a closet.



Build-it-yourself computer

- **What?** Altair 8800
- **Who?** MITS
- **Where and when?** US, 1974

Many of the earliest personal computers were sold as build-it-yourself kits to hobbyists. After the Altair 8800 appeared on the cover of Popular Electronics magazine, it sold in large numbers and kick-started a personal computing revolution.



Computing at home

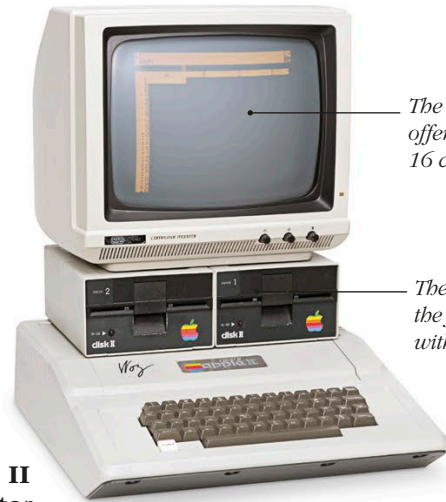
- **What?** Atari 400/800
- **Who?** Atari
- **Where and when?** US, 1979

The first home computers, intended for nontechnical users, arrived in 1979. Leading the pack were models by manufacturers Texas Instruments and, particularly, Atari. Their most common uses were playing video games, but some people used them for word processing and basic programming.

Steve Wozniak's Apple II

- **What?** Apple II
- **Who?** Apple Computer, Inc
- **Where and when?** US, 1977

The Apple II was designed by Steve Wozniak, cofounder of Apple Computer Inc (now just Apple), in 1977. It was one of the first consumer products to be sold by Apple. With color graphics, sound, and a plastic casing, it set the template for all personal computers to follow.



The screen display offers up to 16 colors.

The Apple II was the first computer with a plastic case.

1970s Apple II computer

The first laptop

- **What?** Epson HX-20
- **Who?** Yukio Yokozawa of Seiko
- **Where and when?** Japan, 1981

The Epson HX-20 was the first laptop computer. It was developed by the Seiko company in Japan and marketed internationally by Epson. It was about the size of an 8½ x 11 sheet of paper and weighed 3½lb (1.6kg). The monitor screen was no bigger than that of a calculator.

The Epson HX-20 had a printer like a cash register.



Epson HX-20 laptop, 1981

FAST FACTS

- In the 1950s, computers were commonly referred to as "electronic brains."
- The computer in your smartphone has more processing power than all the computers in the Apollo lander that took men to the moon.
- In 1980, the first 1 GB hard drive cost \$40,000 and weighed more than 500 lb (226 kg).